

☉ The Prodigal Tongue

The first lesson elemental alchemy teaches is to converse with the spirits of the world in the language of the elements they represent. It is the first duty and privilege reclaimed by Hsien as they are endlessly reborn. Using this power, the Shinma speak with rocks, rivers, animals, and even people whose languages they cannot naturally speak (though the speech is always uncanny and clearly magical in origin, the audience understands perfectly).

Commune With Elements: The Hsien may speak directly to the elements, striking up conversations with pools of water, stones, or trees. The spirits of most things are quiet and sluggish creatures, and must be roused — this is, in part, the action of the spent Yugen. Most will have limited perceptions of the world around them — a stone cannot see, for example, though a pool of water may know what has been reflected in its surface. Use of Magnitude deepens and broadens the connection, making reliable information much more likely to emerge from the conversation.

Read Elemental Soul: By calling to the elements composing a soul, the Hsien may link herself, but only for a moment, to that soul, and discern its nature. She may, for example, determine if the soul is a just one by examining her metal soul, and thus possibly learn if the person associated with it is lying.

Speak with Jimu-Tenno: The Hsien are spirits themselves, albeit cut off from what they used to be. Still, they retain the ability to speak to their kin, the elemental spirits of the Yang world who sometimes find their way into the Middle Kingdom.

Speak to Mortals: The Hsien were charged with oversight of the natural world — however, humans too have a role in the natural world, one that seemingly grows with each passing day (though frequently not to the natural world's benefit). Humans are made of the same elemental matter and bear the same elemental souls that beasts, plants, and stones do, and as a result Hsien may, through the use of alchemy, address any human and be understood. Addressing mortals is always a Yang effect, and addressing the dead is always a Yin effect. This I Chih functions regardless of the element used to empower it, unless the subject's relevant elemental soul has been seriously damaged or destroyed (in which case, not understanding the Hsien is the least of her worries).

☉☉ InFlame the Elements; Dampen the Elements

The Shinma were once given command over the spirits of the Middle Kingdom and the Yang world, the better to order them according to Heaven's vision. Now cast out, that authority yet remains, and even young Shinma can often coax the elements into obeying, if only a little, inflaming or dampening the elemental Chi within them — or, indeed, within herself.

Diminish/Nurture Elemental Soul: As she may command elementals, a Hsien may command the elemental energy that animates souls, inflaming or dampening the passions and behaviors associated with that element. Yin is used to diminish behaviors, Yang to amplify them.

Increase/Decrease Elemental Attributes: Similarly, the Hsien may use their authority over the elements to alter Attributes associated with those elements, increasing or decreasing them at a rate of 1 dot per two dice allocated to Degree — three, to lower an Attribute from one to zero. Again, Yin is used to diminish, Yang to amplify.

☉☉☉ Raiment of the Elements

As her understanding grows, the Hsien learns to control her own elemental form, altering her body and learning how little divides her form from the world around her. This I Chih cannot target other individuals — all effects must target the Hsien or an inanimate object. In addition, as her understanding of the elements deepens, her capacity and authority within the Celestial Bureaucracy develops. With the third I Chih in an Alchemy, the Hsien may now exercise power over the elemental spirits of the Middle Kingdom.

Exorcise Elemental Spirit: The Hsien may disperse — but not destroy — an elemental spirit. This requires a die allocated to Degree for every 10 points of Chi the spirit possesses. If the spirit has crossed the Gauntlet and manifested, the sorcery becomes much more difficult, requiring one die per five points of Chi. This is always a Yin effect.

Summon Elemental Spirit: The Hsien summons a spirit of the elements from across the Gauntlet, requiring a die allocated to Degree for every 10 points of Chi the spirit possesses plus one per level of the Gauntlet rating of the current location. Spirits do not enjoy being idly called, and typically require remuneration before obeying the Hsien's dictates. This is always a Yang effect.

Summon the Dragon Boat: Able to be used only in dragon nests, those places where the spiritual energy of the world penetrates into the material realm of the Middle Kingdom, this power allows the Shinma to travel rapidly between them — one die allocated to Degree for every 100 miles of distance, though only between dragon nests that are connected by dragon lines. This requires a small jade figurine of the eponymous dragon boat. The Hsien summons an elemental from across the Gauntlet, and strikes a bargain similar to that needed when Summoning Elemental Spirits. A botch on this roll causes the jade figurine to shatter and befouls the dragon nest — it can be cleansed, but it requires a day's worth of rituals, and those who maintain the dragon nest will not be best pleased.

The Enfolded Object: The Hsien subsumes a small amount of an element within herself, to a maximum of roughly double her mass. The object's spirit merges with the Hsien's, and so it cannot be discovered. Cohort effects must be used to hide an object consisting of more than one element, such as liquid held in a metal container (water and metal) or a burning torch (wood and fire).

Paths of the Elements: The Hsien merges with an element, becoming one with it and thus able to travel freely within it, provided she governs the effect with Domain. Continuance allows the changeling to stay in the substance he has merged with — if he does not leave before the end of the effect, the element expels him violently, and he suffers two health levels of aggravated damage. All Perception rolls made to discern the